



WHEN IT'S TIME TO GO TO HOSPITAL

Many couples feel unsure about when to go to the hospital. If your pregnancy is low risk, you will almost certainly be more comfortable at home at the start of labor and should wait until you're in active labor, when your contractions are regular, occurring every 5–10 minutes, and painful, before going to the hospital. At this stage, the hospital will want to assess how your baby is responding to strong contractions, and you may want some medication for pain. This needs to be administered in a setting where you can be monitored and, in the case of an [epidural](#), can only be given in the hospital.

If your pregnancy is high risk, you have had a prior cesarean, have a breech baby, or carry the streptococcus B bacterium, call the maternity ward to discuss when to go to the hospital.

Once you're in active labor, a final reason to go to the hospital is to make sure your baby is born there. An unplanned home (or car) birth is not best for you or your baby. This is unusual in a first pregnancy, but with subsequent births women are more likely to arrive at the hospital quite dilated or to have an unintended home birth.